



HACKERS and the Open Source Revolution

This piece corrects the confusion created by mainstream media between 'hacker' and 'cracker'. It also considers the history, nature, attributes, ethics and attire of hackers, plus more. Interested in being one yourself, or checking why other people treat you as if you don't fit into 'normal' society? Read on..

The new generation of hackers are turning open source into a powerful force in today's computing world. They are the heirs to an earlier hacking culture that thrived in the 1960s and 1970s when computers were still new—part of a community that believed software should be shared and that all would benefit as a result. These expert programmers and networking wizards trace their lineage back to the first time-sharing minicomputers and the earliest ARPAnet experiments. The members of this community coined the term 'hacker'. Hackers built the Internet and made the UNIX operating system what it is today. Hackers run Usenet and make the World Wide Web work.

Thanks to the advent of relatively low-cost computers and the Internet, the new hackers are immeasurably more numerous, more productive, and more united than their

forebears. They are linked by a common goal—of writing great software; and by a common code -- that such software should be freely available to all.

Hackers sparked the open source revolution

In 1991, Linus Torvalds sent a posting to an Internet newsgroup, asking for advice on how to make a better operating system. His project was a hobby, he said, and would never be 'big and professional'. In 1994, the first working version of Linux was distributed.

Marleen Wynants and Jan Cornelis, while discussing the economic, social, and cultural impact of Free and Open Source Software in their paper 'How Open is the Future?' suggest that Linux was more than just a toy for hackers. Propelled by Linux, the open source hacker culture surfaced from its underground location. Amateur hacker programmers